

Agree to disagree: additive particles in responses*

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Abstract Most literature on *too* has focused on its “regular” uses, where, as a first approximation, *too* triggers a presupposition that one of the focus alternatives to its prejacent, distinct from the prejacent itself, is true (e.g., *Axel likes cats. BROOK likes cats, too.*). There has also been some discussion of “refutational *too*”, which is used in positive polarity responses that refute the antecedent utterance (e.g., *A: You didn’t do your homework. B: I did too!*). Most recently, Thomas (2023) proposed that refutational *too* is a response particle, akin to *yes* and *no*—or even more pertinently, to French *si* and German *doch*. In this paper, I present novel data on what I will call “confirmatory *too*”, which is used in positive polarity responses that confirm the antecedent utterance (e.g., *A: We defeated her! B: You did too.*), as well as some additional data on some other additive particles in responses. I argue against the response particle analysis of such uses, proposing instead that both refutational and confirmatory uses of additive particles share their core semantics with their regular uses, with the difference being the focus alternatives: alternative projected commitments with respect to a polar issue *p*? (a subcase or a sibling of verum focus) in refutational cases vs. alternative performances of a speech act making the same projected commitment (a subcase of dictum focus) in confirmatory cases.

Keywords: additive particles, response particles, verum focus, dictum focus, English

1 Introduction

Most literature on *too* (and similar additive particles) has focused on its uses as in (1) (hf. “regular *too*”).

(1) Axel likes cats. [BROOK]_F likes cats, TOO.

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As a first approximation (to be revised), regular *too* triggers a presupposition that one of the focus alternatives to its prejacent, distinct from the prejacent itself, is true.

There has also been some discussion of “refutational *too*”, which is used in positive polarity responses that refute the antecedent utterance (e.g., [Rullmann 2003](#); [Schwenter & Waltereit 2010](#); [Sailor 2014](#); [Thomas 2023](#)):

- (2) A: You didn’t do your homework.
 B: {Did too! / I did too! / I did too do my homework!}
- (3) A: I think I could survive in the woods for, like, a really long time.
 B: You made this fire with an ‘Us Weekly’ magazine, gasoline, and a ‘Hooters’ <bleep> lighter. No, you could not, Steve.
 A: I could too! (‘kallmekris’ YouTube channel; ‘too-ref-survive’)

[Thomas \(2023\)](#) proposes that refutational *too* is a [REVERSE, +] response particle in terms of [Roelofsen & Farkas 2015](#), akin to French *si* and German *doch*. Such particles are used in responses (i) with positive prejacent (the [+] feature, which tracks absolute polarity and contrasts with [−]) (ii) to negative antecedents,¹ thus, reversing the polarity of the antecedent (the [REVERSE] feature, which tracks relative polarity and contrasts with [AGREE]). This is illustrated for French *si* in (4), where *si* realizes both [REVERSE] and [+], whereas in the English translations, *yes* only realizes [+] and *no* only realizes [REVERSE].

- (4) A: i. Nina n’a pas passé l’examen.
 Nina NEG-has NEG passed the-exam
 ‘Nina didn’t pass the exam.’

¹ For the purposes of this paper, I will set aside the issue of what exactly counts as a negative antecedent, but empirically, both French *si* and refutational *too* are licensed in response to ‘I doubt that *p*’-type antecedents (although some French speakers might prefer *si si* in this case as well as some other cases; the exact nature of the contrasts between *si* vs. *si si* is way beyond the scope of this paper), so it can’t be just morphosyntactic negation:

- (i) A: I doubt that you did your homework.
 B: {Did too! / I did too! / I did too do my homework!}
- (ii) A: Je doute que Nina a gagné.
 I doubt that Nina has won
 ‘I doubt that Nina won.’
 B: Si (si), elle a gagné.
 SI (SI) she has won
 ≈ ‘{Yes(,) she did (win). / No, she did (win).}’

ii. Est-ce que Nina n'a pas passé l'examen?
 is-it that Nina NEG-has NEG passed the-exam
 'Did Nina not pass the exam?'

B: {Si (si) / *oui / ??non}, elle l'a passé.
 {SI (SI) / *OUI / ??NON} she it-has passed
 ≈ '{Yes(.) she did (pass). / No, she did (pass).}'

Based on examples like (5) (adapted from [Romero & Han 2004](#)), [Thomas \(2023\)](#) also argues that refutational *too* is further distinct from particles like *si* and *doch* in that it requires a stronger bias for $\neg p$ in the antecedent, which negative antecedents—and in particular, negative polar questions—don't always convey.

(5) *Context: B is organizing a party and is in charge of supplying all the non-alcoholic beverages for teetotalers. A and B are going through a list of people that are invited. B has no previous belief or expectation about their drinking habits.*

A: Jane and Mary do not drink.

B: OK. What about John? Does he not drink (either)?

A: He does (#too)! ([Thomas 2023](#): (17a))

Because of this, Thomas posits another feature for refutational *too*, [REFUTE]. He argues that this bias for $\neg p$ in the antecedent doesn't always have to be as strong as a full commitment, but it's stronger than simply putting $\neg p$ on the table. So he recruits the notion of “projected commitments” from [Malamud & Stephenson 2015](#), which include both full commitments and “propositions which [an] interlocutor believes (and therefore expects to commit to in the future) but wishes to delay committing to”. Thus, his [REFUTE] requires that $\neg[\text{prejacent}] \in DC_{Ad}^*$, where DC_{Ad}^* are addressee's projected commitments.

In this paper, I discuss “confirmatory *too*”, which, to my knowledge, has not been discussed in the formal literature before and which is used in positive polarity responses that confirm the antecedent utterance, as in (6).

(6) A: We defeated her!

B: You did too. ('The Weekly Planet' podcast; 'too-conf-defeated')

I also provide some additional data on refutational and confirmatory uses of some other additive particles. All these data are discussed in section 2. I then argue against the response particle analysis of refutational or confirmatory uses of additive particles in section 3. Instead, in section 4, I propose that such uses of additive particles share their core semantics with their regular uses, with the difference being

the focus alternatives: alternative projected commitments with respect to a polar issue *p*? (a subcase or a sibling of verum focus) in refutational cases vs. alternative performances of a speech act making the same projected commitment (a subcase of dictum focus) in confirmatory cases. I also add some brief notes on the syntax and prosody of additive particles in responses in section 5 and wrap up in section 6.

2 New data on additive particles in responses

2.1 Confirmatory *too*

In (7–10), I provide some naturalistic examples of confirmatory *too* (additional examples can be found in the appendix at <https://doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/EMWQG>, subfolder ‘esipova-salt35-proceedings’). Note that there’s no additional context in any of them that would license a regular *too* reading. Besides, in the audio files for (9–10), one can hear that the accented items are the auxiliary and *too* itself (which it typically is in regular uses, as well), i.e., nothing else is focus-marked. In other words, the target utterances are meant to be interpreted similarly to utterances with *indeed* (‘He is indeed. / It is indeed. / etc.’), confirming the antecedent utterance.

- (7) A: Hey! The new frog striker looks like you, Gav!
 B: Yeah, he does too! (The British National Corpus (BNC), J1H)
- (8) A: Ann Kidd thought it might also be related to the move from sheep to cows, because sheep didn’t...
 B: Oh, right, yes.
 A: It’s very interesting.
 B: Yes, that’s interesting. It is too. Yes, Trish. (FitzSimons 2010, accessed via the Language Data Commons of Australia (LDaCA))
- (9) A: We defeated her!
 B: You did too. (‘The Weekly Planet’ podcast;² ‘too-conf-defeated’)
- (10) A: I was gonna say, on TV, he was Rick Springfield, of ‘Jessie’s Girl’³s fame.
 B: He was too, wasn’t he! (‘The Weekly Planet’ podcast; ‘too-conf-rick’)

There is ostensible regional dialectal variation regarding the availability of refutational vs. confirmatory *too*. All naturalistic examples of confirmatory *too* I have collected so far come from British or Australian English speakers/corpora. Out of the 10 speakers I have polled (4 from the US, 4 from England, 1 from Scotland, 1

² Both speakers on this podcast are Australian.

from Australia), there's a slight tendency for refutational *too* to be associated with American English and a clear tendency for confirmatory *too* to be associated with British and Australian English, but, importantly, 5 speakers accept both.³

It is also worth noting that many of the confirmatory *too* examples I have involve information (re-)acquisition (e.g., in (11) and (12)), and in these cases, there can be a surprise component there, as well. One might try to conjecture then that this is still in some way refutational *too*, but what one is refuting is their prior expectations.⁴ However, counter-expectation or even information acquisition is not a requirement for confirmatory *too*; e.g., (9) above sounds like a simple confirmation, and (13) below is very clearly not an information acquisition context for the speaker producing the utterance with confirmatory *too*. Furthermore and most importantly, people who accept refutational *too*, but don't accept confirmatory *too* don't accept the latter regardless of whether it's an information (re-)acquisition context.

- (11) A: Oh there's your bra.
B: Oh it is too. (Peters 1996b, accessed via LDaCA)
- (12) A: A little cameo, which we won't spoil until spoilers, I think.
B: A cameo, Mason?
A: Yeah-yeah.
B: Oh yeah, there is too! I forgot about that!
A: Not of an actor! Oh but there is a cameo! I'm talking about... I'm thinking about... <disfluency> There's some character cameos, and there's an actor cameo, which we'll talk about.
B: Oh, there is too! I completely forgot! ('The Weekly Planet' podcast; 'too-conf-cameo')
- (13) A: It's in Barrett.
B: Oh it's in Barrett.
A: That's right, it is too. (Peters 1996a, accessed via LDaCA)

Let me also note that in (11) above and (14) below, the exact form of the antecedent is not preserved, but the impersonal *it* construction is used instead. It

³ More specifically: 2 speakers from England have both uses; 1 speaker from England only has confirmatory *too* and believes refutational *too* is American English; 1 speaker from England doesn't have either, but might recognize refutational *too* from US media; 3 US speakers only have refutational *too*, with two of them recognizing confirmatory *too* and associating it with British English; 1 US speaker kinda accepts both, but finds confirmatory *too* more marked; the Australian and Scottish speakers accept both. Besides, Craig Sailor (p.c.), who has worked on refutational *too* (Sailor 2014), didn't observe any clear regional restrictions on refutational *too*.

⁴ Similarly to how some people have been trying to explain away some cases of what I believe is dictum focus as verum focus—an issue I will briefly come back to in subsection 4.2.

remains to be seen how wide-spread this neutralized version of confirmatory *too* utterances is, but it could be indicative of a movement towards idiomatization as a general-purpose confirmatory utterance akin to *(That's) right*.

- (14) A: There's a robot arm! Maybe that's the robot arm!
 B: Shit! Shit! It was too! ('The Weekly Planet' podcast; 'too-conf-arm')

2.2 Other additive particles in responses

Rullmann (2003); Thomas (2023) also note the existence of refutational *either* in responses with negative polarity prejacent for some speakers (under Thomas's analysis, it is then a [REVERSE, –, REFUTE] particle):

- (15) A: It's the Callaway house. Nobody's lived there for years. It's haunted.
 B: It's not either! (The Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA), 'It takes two'; cited from Thomas 2023: (25), with a correction)

While I wasn't able to find confirmatory uses of *either*, Gary Thoms (p.c.) pointed out to me that confirmatory *neither* exists in some varieties of English in Scotland and Northern Ireland, in responses and/or as an emphatic tag:

- (16) A: It's not a very nice night.
 B: Neither it is, been rain all day. (Gary Thoms, p.c.)
 (17) It's no a very nice day, neither it is. (The Scots Syntax Atlas)

I have also found some corpus examples of what looks like confirmatory and refutational *as well*⁵ (note that in (19), the speaker appears to be refuting their own assertion, having changed their mind mid-utterance):

- (18) A: She had a good (...) education.
 B: She had as well, yeah. (BNC, K60)
 (19) ...this has nothing to do with my er well no it has as well. (BNC, HES)

Let me also note the similarity between the confirmatory uses of additive particles we have been discussing here and the "emphatic assertion" uses (for the lack of a better term) like in (20).⁶ However, these emphatic assertion uses seem to be much more widely accepted by English speakers (at least for some of the cases in (20)) than confirmatory ones, suggesting that the two are still distinct. I will briefly come back to what the analytical difference between the two might be in subsection 4.2.

⁵ However, Craig Sailor (p.c.) told me that, to his knowledge, refutational *as well* does not exist. So it is possible that it is rare or that I am misinterpreting the example in (19).

⁶ These emphatic assertion uses of additive particles are also definitely attested cross-linguistically, e.g., for Hungarian *is* 'too, indeed' (Koopman & Szabolcsi 2000).

- (20) a. Damn, I thought he knew everything. He did too. (COCA, ‘Babylon 5’;
‘too-emph-knew’)
- b. He curled his arm round Claudia’s waist, smiling at the receptionist in a way that made her assure him she would keep his secret. She would too... (BNC, H8J)
- c. She says, ‘You did that to me’ and I suppose I did too because I am terrified of snakes. (FitzSimons 2010, accessed via LDaCA)
- d. Baby, do you reckon he’s gonna get on the top? Ah, he did as well! (‘sknud.world’ Instagram account; ‘as-well-emph-top’)

There are also many similarities between confirmatory/refutational *too* and confirmatory/refutational *so* (see, e.g., Sailor 2014 for a discussion of refutational uses of both), but I am setting the latter aside, since *so* is not an additive particle.

It remains to be seen how wide-spread this phenomenon of using additive particles in refutations and confirmations is, especially cross-linguistically, but the more general nature of this phenomenon at least in English is something to keep in mind when developing an analysis thereof.

3 Arguments against the response particle analysis

I will now put forward three arguments against the response particle analysis of refutational and confirmatory uses of additive particles.

First, it would be typologically odd for a single lexical item to have both refutational and confirmatory uses qua a response particle. Thomas (2023) hypothesizes a [CONFIRM] feature—the reverse of his [REFUTE]—which “would presuppose that its prejacent is a member of [the addressee’s projected commitments]”. Confirmatory *too* would then be a good candidate for realizing [CONFIRM], except it would be typologically weird for the same lexical item to be able to realize both of two opposing features—including within the same speaker. That would be equivalent to the same particle being able to realize both [+] and [−] or both [AGREE] and [REVERSE], and I’m unaware of any such cases cross-linguistically.

Note that this argument is not about ambiguity—ambiguity is omnipresent in natural language. For instance, ambiguity is common with response particles like English *yes* and *no*, which can realize both absolute and relative polarity, in contexts where absolute and relative polarity don’t match. Instead, the argument here is about the weirdness of the same item lexicalizing to realize two contradictory meanings.

Note also that if one were to maintain a response particle analysis of refutational and confirmatory *too*, one will also have to posit that all those other additive particles mentioned in subsection 2.2 have also re-lexicalized as response particles—and in some cases, also with contradictory feature combinations.

The second argument is that in these uses of additive particles in responses the prejacents are obligatory—which is not the case for regular response particles. Thomas (2023) acknowledges this, but notes that the Romanian *ba* particle can't occur by itself either (Farkas & Bruce 2010). This note is misleading, however, because *ba* is always part of a particle cluster *ba nu* or *ba da*, which can, in fact, be standalone utterances without an overt prejacents. The same is true for Russian *da net* ≈ 'but no', where the adversative particle *da* is a prosodic clitic and can't occur on its own, but *da net* can (see, e.g., Esipova 2021).

Anticipating a little bit, I will propose that this obligatoriness of the prejacents is due to the fact that additive particles still must associate with focus even in these uses in responses while regular response particles don't associate with focus.

Finally, the third argument is that the response particle analysis is simply superfluous, because the additive particles we observe in refutations and confirmations already have the key properties that motivated the response particle analysis in their regular uses. Thomas (2023) adopts a response particle analysis for refutational *too* because "it exhibits what [he] take[s] to be the two key properties of polarity particles: anaphoric reference to a salient antecedent sentence (...) and sensitivity to the polarity of that antecedent and/or its prejacents". But the additive particles we have discussed are already sensitive to the prejacents's polarity, with *too* and *as well* typically requiring a positive prejacents and (*n*)*either*—a negative one.

Likewise, these additive particles are also anaphoric. Thus, Kripke (2009) argues against the simplistic generalization about *too* we started with in the Introduction: "[*t*]oo (...) should refer to parallel elements", which "must come from the active context or from other clauses in the assertion (...). [T]hat they are merely very well known is not sufficient". (21) illustrates this point, as it still requires a salient antecedent—our general world knowledge that someone other than Sam is bound to be having dinner in New York on any given night is insufficient to license *too*.

(21) [SAM]_F is having dinner in New York tonight, too. (Kripke 2009: (14))

Thus, I conclude that the jump to a response particle analysis is unjustified, and we can account for uses of additive particles in confirmations and refutations using the same core semantics as for their regular uses, which already have sensitivity to absolute polarity and anaphoricity, like response particles—but also association with focus, which response particles don't have.

Before I introduce my proposal, let me acknowledge that there are additional idiosyncrasies in these response uses of additive particles (e.g., the apparent ban on indefinite subjects at least in refutational *too* cases, discussed in Thomas 2023; the potentially more categorical nature of the sensitivity to the polarity of the prejacents; etc.), and, more broadly, there does appear to be a certain level of idiomatization in these uses. But the response particle analysis doesn't fare much better in explaining

most of these idiosyncrasies. It is entirely possible that some of the additive particles we have discussed are on their way to re-lexicalize as response particles (see also the discussion at the very end of subsection 2.1), in which case the proposal in the next section can also be viewed as a hypothesis about the relevant diachronic pathway. However, as is, I believe that this re-lexicalization has not happened in full yet.

4 Proposal: regular additive semantics for additive particles in responses

As I lay out my proposal, I focus on *too*, but the analysis is easily extendable, mutatis mutandis, to other similar uses of additive particles in responses. Following Kripke 2009, I assume that *too* requires that its “active context” must contain a “parallel element” to its prejacent. The exact nature of said “parallel element” may need to be refined further, but let’s say for concreteness and simplicity that it is an element from the set of focus alternatives to the prejacent of *too*, distinct from the prejacent itself.

4.1 Refutational uses of additive particles: analysis

As a reminder, Thomas (2023) introduces the [REFUTE] feature to account for the fact that, unlike [REVERSE, +] particles like French *si* and German *doch*, refutational *too* requires that the addressee have expressed a bias for the negative version of the prejacent. Thomas claims that this bias doesn’t always have to be as strong as a full commitment, but it’s stronger than simply putting $\neg p$ on the table. So he cashes out his [REFUTE] feature in terms of projected commitments from Malamud & Stephenson 2015, which include both full commitments and “propositions which that interlocutor believes (and therefore expects to commit to in the future) but wishes to delay committing to”. Thus, his [REFUTE] requires that $\neg[\text{prejacent}] \in DC_{Ad}^*$, where DC_{Ad}^* are addressee’s projected commitments.

For the purposes of concreteness, I am going to keep Thomas’s insight that refutational *too* operates at the level of projected commitments—although I come back to the issue of whether this is the right analytical notion to use here later in this section—but I propose that utterances with refutational *too* evoke them as focus alternatives. Of course, if it turns out that empirically, projected commitments are not the best notion to capture the bias requirement of refutational *too*, the proposed analysis can be easily adjusted accordingly.

Now, note that not only do utterances with refutational *too* have to have an overt prejacent, this prejacent must have an accentable unreduced auxiliary. In fact, the prejacent can consist just of the auxiliary, but the auxiliary is obligatory even with non-elliptical prejacentes. All this is unexplained under the response particle analysis. Under the view pursued here, refutational *too* is still an additive particle that still must have an overt focus associate. I propose that utterances with refutational *too*

have a subcase or a sibling of *verum focus*, but one that specifically evokes alternative projected commitments with respect to a polar issue p ?. This focus is realized as an accent on the highest auxiliary,⁷ and, thus, an unreduced auxiliary is required in utterances with refutational *too*.

Now, for the purposes of this paper, I remain agnostic with respect to the exact relationship between what is typically called “*verum focus*” in the literature and the focus we have to posit for refutational *too*—as well as with respect to the exact taxonomy of semantic foci that are realized as an accent on the highest auxiliary in English.⁸ However, there are definitely cases of accented auxiliaries in English that do not involve any commitments and are ostensibly just polarity focus—which would be insufficient for refutational *too*, as it is not licensed in these cases:

- (22) Maybe Avery DIDN’T do their homework, maybe they DID (#too) (do their homework).

The focus we need for refutational *too* is also distinct from whatever happens in polar questions like in (23) (again, I remain agnostic on whether the focus in (23) is itself reducible to the focus in (22)).

- (23) A: I did my homework.
B: DID you (#too) (do your homework)?

Then, in line with the core semantics of *too*, refutational *too* requires that there be an alternative projected commitment in the active context (technically, by any interlocutor) with respect to the issue p ? to the one made by its prejacent. Combining this with (i) the general requirement that the prejacent of *too* have positive polarity;⁹ (ii) the fact that a polar issue p ? can only be resolved as p or $\neg p$; and (iii) the fact that the same conversation participant cannot have both p or $\neg p$ simultaneously in their projected commitments—we get the requirement that there be a projected commitment to $\neg p$ in the active context by someone other than the speaker,¹⁰ i.e., essentially the same requirement as that of Thomas’s [REFUTE] feature. The same

7 Of course, in negative sentences, it can also be realized on *not*, as in (15).

8 Although I do think that some cases that have been categorized in the literature as *verum focus* are actually dictum focus, which I come back to in subsection 4.2.

9 The exact polarity requirements of *too* are ostensibly more complex. For instance, Rullmann (2003) claims essentially that *either* is an NPI, and *too* competes with it—with some additional assumptions. It is entirely possible that the polarity requirements of additive particles used in responses have been idiomatized to be more categorical. As I have noted before at the end of section 3, there is a substantial degree of idiomatization in these uses.

10 Although technically it can be the same speaker abruptly changing their mind and correcting themselves, which is what seems to happen in (19)—but this potential for “arguing with yourself” applies to response particles, as well, of course.

logic applies to refutational *as well* (if it indeed exists) and to refutational *either*, but with a negative polarity requirement for the prejacent in the latter case.

One thing that still needs to be discussed at this point is whether refutational *too* does in fact require a negative antecedent—which, if true, might not be captured by the analysis above, depending on one’s definition of projected commitments. Recall that [Thomas \(2023\)](#) posits the [REFUTE] feature in addition to, not instead of [REVERSE]. He does raise the question of whether the [REVERSE] feature is still needed if the [REFUTE] feature is posited—and for a good reason: conceptually, it is awkward to posit both, given the substantial overlap in the empirical ground they cover. Note also that the exact formulation of [REVERSE] and what counts as a negative antecedent is itself unclear, and at the very least, morphosyntactic negation in the antecedent is not actually needed for either particles like French *si* or refutational *too*, as they are both licensed by ‘I doubt that *p*’-type antecedents, as noted previously in footnote 1. It is thus possible that the ultimate optimal formulation of [REVERSE], based on the behavior of actual response particles like French *si* and German *doch*, would bring it even closer to Thomas’s [REFUTE].

All that said, Thomas ends up concluding that [REVERSE] is still needed for refutational *too*, albeit somewhat tentatively. His conclusion is based on examples like (24–25), where he claims that refutational *too* is not licensed. His reasoning then is as follows: (i) [REFUTE] requires the addressee to have expressed a projected commitment to $\neg p$; (ii) A’s utterances in (24–25) do express such a commitment; (iii) refutational *too* is not licensed in B’s responses in (24–25)—therefore, a negative antecedent is needed in addition to a projected commitment to $\neg p$ by the addressee.

(24) *Context: A and B are exploring an abandoned house that a friend told them was haunted. They look for evidence of paranormal activity but don’t find any.*

A: Is this house really haunted?

B: It is (#too)! ([Thomas 2023](#): (20a))

(25) *Context: A and B are discussing a birthday party that they are planning to host for their friend Cameron.*

A: Dana volunteered to bake the cake.

B: (Really?) Dana can bake?

A: He can (#too)! ([Thomas 2023](#): (20b))

First, let me note that the speakers I asked had mixed and sometimes less categorical judgements regarding the availability of refutational *too* in examples like (24–25).¹¹ That said, overall, they do seem to be more reluctant to accept refutational

11 Actually, the French and German speakers I consulted also had somewhat less categorical judgements

too in such cases, i.e., an explanation is still needed. However, it is not at all clear that Thomas’s reasoning steps in (i)–(iii) above provide such an explanation.

Thomas defines projected commitments as follows: “any proposition p that a speaker publicly expresses any degree of belief in is immediately added to that speaker’s projected commitment set”. This is a very weak and vague requirement, and I also don’t necessarily think that it matches the notion of projected commitments in Malamud & Stephenson 2015 or the intentions with which it was used there. My understanding of the notion of projected commitments in Malamud & Stephenson 2015 is that an utterance can only signal a projected commitment (attributed to the speaker or the addressee) to its prejacent, not its negation or any of its inferences. At least, Malamud & Stephenson (2015) only use projected commitments for such cases, as they use them for “declarative utterances [that] (...) render the assertion expressed by the attached declarative tentative in some way”, namely, tag questions and non-inquisitive rising declaratives. This implies to me that even though A’s utterances in (24–25) suggest some form of bias for $\neg p$ (‘This house is not haunted’ and ‘Dana cannot bake’, respectively) on A’s part, $\neg p$ is not, in fact, added to A’s projected commitments when they produce these utterances—not under the understanding of projected commitments in Malamud & Stephenson 2015.

More generally, all that (24–25) seem to show is that, empirically, refutational *too* requires a stronger or simply a different kind of bias for $\neg p$ in the antecedent than what Thomas formulated in his definition of projected commitments, which he then used to define [REFUTE]. If anything, the data in (24–25) should be an indication that either a different definition of projected commitments is needed—or that a different analytical notion is needed altogether for capturing the bias requirement of refutational *too*. Nothing in (24–25), however, suggests that the issue is specifically the polarity of the antecedent, and we already saw that the polarity of the antecedent alone does not license refutational *too*—Thomas himself shows that—so it’s unclear why he concludes that the polarity of the antecedent is somehow relevant in (24–25) or that it’s directly relevant at all for licensing refutational *too*.

Thomas also discusses examples like (26), where he claims that the bias for $\neg p$ in the antecedent is “weak”, the logic thus ostensibly being that refutational *too* is actually satisfied even with a “weak” bias for $\neg p$, but it also needs a negative antecedent; (24–25) then satisfy the former requirement, but not the latter.

(26) *Context: A and B have a dog, Fido, which B is supposed to feed every day. One day, A comes home and sees Fido lying next to his empty bowl, looking hungry.*

A: Did you not feed Fido?

for *si* and *doch* in the counterparts of (24–25)—further highlighting that the exact requirements of so-called [REVERSE, +] response particles are not at all clear either.

B: I did too! (Thomas 2023: (18))

However, Thomas’s claim that the bias for $\neg p$ in A’s question in (26) is weak seems to be based solely on the claims in the prior literature (e.g., Romero & Han 2004) that “low negation polar questions do not require any speaker bias”. But first, this is a logical fallacy: just because a question form doesn’t require a bias doesn’t mean that questions using this form cannot have a bias, including a strong one. There is also a further issue here of whether these claims in the prior literature are correct or complete. For one thing, they seem to ignore the difference between polarity-seeking vs. explanation-seeking interpretations of polar questions (term from Esipova & Romero 2023). Low negation polar questions in English can have both interpretations. Thus, B’s question ‘Does he not drink?’ in (5) is ostensibly a polarity-seeking question, with no non-trivial higher order QUD and no bias either way, while A’s question in (26) is an explanation-seeking question, with a higher order ‘What is the explanation for this contextual evidence?’-type QUD, where the prejacent p (in this case, ‘You did not feed Fido’) is one of the potential explanations. Explanation-seeking questions are definitionally biased (there has to be some contextual evidence for which p would be a likely explanation). The polarity-seeking vs. explanation-seeking interpretations of regular polar questions are typically not distinguished in English on the surface (but they typically are, e.g., in Russian—again, see Esipova & Romero 2023). Thus, while it is technically true that “low negation polar questions do not require any speaker bias” in English, these questions are also not a homogeneous class, and this statement is only true for polarity-seeking low negation polar questions.

For what it’s worth, I think that the bias for $\neg p$ in A’s utterance in (26) is, in fact, quite strong. But what is likely even more relevant for our purposes is that (26) vs. (24–25) differ in the type of bias, how it is signalled, and whether any other types of bias are present. A related point is that under the analysis proposed here, we could hypothesize that the reason (or one of the reasons) why refutational *too* might be less readily available in cases like (24–25) is the lower salience of the relevant focus alternative. In other words, we could maintain that (i) the focus alternatives evoked in refutational *too* cases are indeed alternative projected commitments with respect to the issue p ? and even that (ii) A’s utterances in (24–25) do in fact make a projected commitment to $\neg p$ —but the way this commitment is expressed might not be salient enough for the anaphoric requirement of *too*. Thus, we still have no evidence that refutational *too* has a requirement for a negative antecedent that is independent from the focus alternatives evoked, combined with the general properties of *too* (i.e., its anaphoricity and positive polarity requirement for the prejacent).

4.2 Confirmatory uses of additive particles: analysis

Confirmatory *too* also requires an overt prejacent with an accentable auxiliary. I thus propose that utterances with confirmatory *too* have a subcase of *dictum focus*. Since this type of focus has been less discussed than verum focus, let me properly introduce it first. [Creswell \(2000\)](#) coins the term “dictum focus” and proposes that one way of treating it is to posit that it evokes alternative “performances of the speech act with identical propositional content”, varying with respect to the speaker and/or time of utterance. In (27–30), I provide some examples of dictum focus.

- (27) A: How are we getting there?
 B: I don’t know. How ARE we getting there? ([Creswell 2000](#): (10))
- (28) A: Who’s to say?
 B: Who IS to say? (‘The Weekly Planet’ podcast; ‘dictum-say’)
- (29) A: Diedrich Bader is in this.
 B: Diedrich Bader IS in this.
 A: He’s the voice of Batman sometimes.
 B: He sometimes IS. (‘The Weekly Planet’ podcast; ‘dictum-bader’)
- (30) A: I mean, he just lost all of his pieces, let’s be fair, let’s...
 B: He DID lose all of his pieces! (‘GMHikaru’ YouTube channel; ‘dictum-lose’)

[Creswell \(2000\)](#) focuses on dictum focus in wh-questions, since these cases are clearly not reducible to verum focus, but I also classify assertions like in (29–30) as instances of dictum focus. There have been attempts to reduce such cases to verum focus (e.g., [Bill & Koev 2021](#); [Goodhue 2022](#)), but I find them unconvincing—and also unnecessary, since the notion of dictum focus is independently needed.

Similarly to refutational *too* and verum focus, I propose that utterances with confirmatory *too* have a more narrow subcase of dictum focus, specifically one evoking alternative performances of a speech act making a certain projected commitment. This narrowing is once again needed because, similarly to refutational *too* and verum focus, confirmatory *too* cannot be used, for instance, in questions with dictum focus (cf. *indeed*, *yeah*, *right*—which would all be good in (31)):

- (31) A: How are we getting there?
 B: How ARE we (#too) (getting there)?

Combining this with the core semantics of *too*, confirmatory *too* then requires that there be an alternative performance of a speech act in the active context making the

same projected commitment as its prejacent (i.e., essentially the same requirement as Thomas’s purported [CONFIRM] feature), which must have positive polarity. Once again, this extends, *mutatis mutandis*, to confirmatory uses of other additive particles.

We are also now in a position to formulate what the intuitive difference is between confirmatory uses of additive particles and what we previously labeled “emphatic assertions” in cases like (20). While the focus alternatives in confirmatory uses are alternative performances of a speech act making the same projected commitment, in cases like (20), we seem to have a contrast between actually asserting *p* in the prejacent of *too* vs. doing something weaker in the antecedent, like evoking some evidence for *p*.¹² How exactly the alternatives are constrained in these “emphatic assertion” cases, and consequently, how this intuition should be cashed out analytically is, however, beyond the scope of this paper.

Let me also acknowledge that, as is, assuming more narrow cases of *verum* and *dictum* focus is *ad hoc*, but so is positing the [REFUTE]/[CONFIRM] features. Ideally, the existence of either phenomenon needs to be independently argued for, but the response particle analysis has all the additional issues discussed in section 3.

5 Notes on syntax and prosody

Before I wrap up, let me add very brief discussions of the syntax and prosody of additive particles in responses.

5.1 Notes on syntax

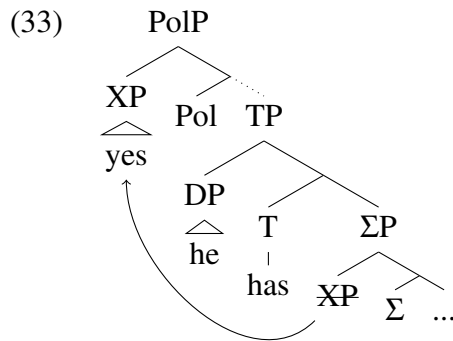
Sailor (2014) observes that refutational *too* cannot co-occur with prosodically integrated response particles like *yes* within the same clause:

- (32) A: John hasn’t left.
B: { Yes he has! / He has too! / *Yes he has too! }

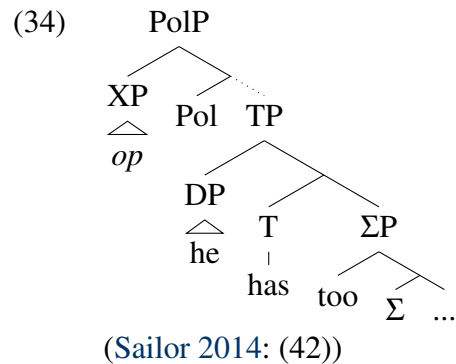
He takes this as evidence that *yes* and *too* in these cases originate in the same position, but then *yes* obligatorily moves:

¹² This also seems to be part of or related to the broad phenomenon of alternatives that combine a proposition *p* with different modal or attitude operators, for instance:

- (i) I used to say, ‘Alice, you’re gonna set the world on fire, girl.’ And I believe she could have too. (COCA, ‘Antioch Review’)
- (ii) Ronny felt like screaming at them right then and there in the street. She might have too but for how the cutie pie Israelis in their expensive shoes would stare and stare. (COCA, ‘The Maine Review’)

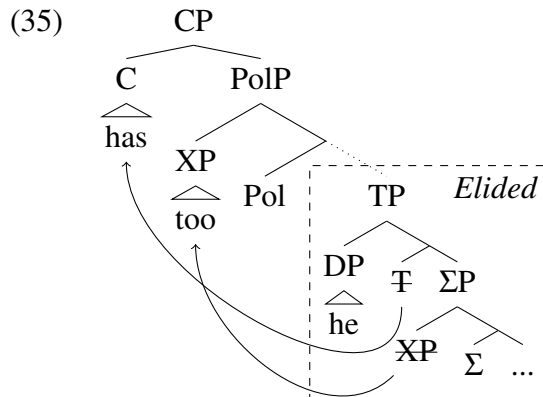


(Sailor 2014: (41))



While I remain agnostic about the details, my view is largely compatible with the general syntax–semantics set-up where *yes* and *too* in cases like (32) do indeed originate in the same position or move through the same position—hence their complementary distribution—and, thus, they do share some meaning component(s) (e.g., the sensitivity to the polarity of the prejacent). However, under my view, *yes* has an additional meaning component (or components) that triggers this obligatory movement to some higher discourse-related position and that makes it a true response particle (the $[+]$ feature simply tracks the absolute polarity of the utterance and is not specific to responses). *Too* has additional meaning components, as well, in particular, association with focus. As is, I don't have a reason to assume that confirmatory and refutational *too* live in different syntactic positions, but their focus associates do.

Going back to Sailor's story, *yes*-like particles have to move, with the prejacent TP then being able to be elided. *Too*-like particles either don't move, so only VP ellipsis is possible, or both *too* and the auxiliary move, yielding subjectless retorts (impossible with *yes*); Sailor proposes the following structure for the latter:



(Sailor 2014: (67))

Let me add a few further comments in this respect. First, contrary to (33,35), I don't think that *too* in subjectless retorts moves to the same position to which *yes*-like particles move. For one thing, the latter movement is obligatory while the former is optional. Second, under my proposal, in subjectless retorts with *too*, the auxiliary has to evacuate before everything below *too* gets elided, because, once again, *too* must associate with an overt focused constituent—this property of additive particles gets ignored in both Sailor 2014 and Thomas 2023. In other words, we don't need a syntactic explanation for this obligatory evacuation of the auxiliary.

I should also note that I am yet to see examples of subjectless confirmations with *too*; if they aren't possible, that would suggest that there are syntactic differences between refutational and confirmatory *too*, which would be unexpected if the only difference between them is [REFUTE] vs. [CONFIRM], but which could be accommodated somewhat less stipulatively if at least their focus associates occupy different syntactic positions.

5.2 Notes on prosody

Sailor (2014) argues that refutations with *too* (and other types of retorts) typically bear the “contradiction contour” (L*+H L-H% in ToBI terms) and are “degraded or infelicitous” without one, and that *too* is the thing that bears this entire contour. In retorts with *yes*, either *yes* or the auxiliary can bear the L*+H accent of this contour:

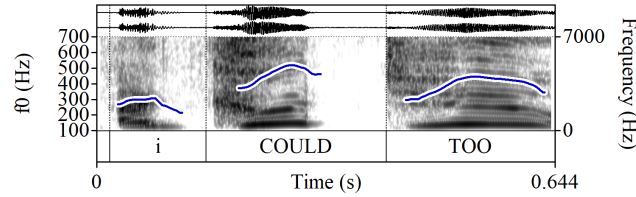
- (36) a. {(I) did [TOO]_{L*+H L-H%} / *(I) [DID too]_{L*+H L-H%} }
 b. {[YES I did]_{L*+H L-H%} / Yes I [DID]_{L*+H L-H%} }

Sailor devises a syntax–prosody story for why that's the case, building on the derivations in (33–35), which, among other things, relies on the L*+H pitch accent being a realization of Σ.

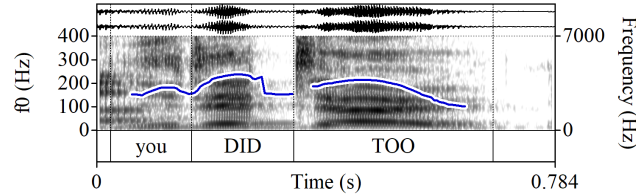
I have a few notes in response to this. First, regular *too* also must bear a pitch accent (this also seems to be the case for other additive particles), so we don't need a separate story for why the second production in (36a) is bad: it leaves *too* accentless. Second, I don't think that responses with refutational *too* actually always have the contradiction contour—for instance, *I could too* from (3) doesn't, as shown in (37). Third, both refutations and confirmations with *too* seem to also bear a pitch accent on the auxiliary, as shown in (37–38),¹³ although, admittedly, it is often hard to see what exactly is going on prosodically in such responses, as they tend to be very short, and it does look like this pitch accent on the auxiliary can often be quite reduced.

¹³ Sailor (2014) mentions the pitch accent on the auxiliary in refutations with *too* briefly in fn. 23 on p. 103, but doesn't analyze it in any way: “The prosody of the [Clause-Internal Polarity retort] strategy likely also involves a pitch accent of some kind on T (...), as there tends to be a slight rise and break immediately before the polarity particle in such retorts; I leave this aside”.

(37) *I could too* from (3) ('too-ref-survive-cropped')



(38) *You did too* from (9) ('too-conf-defeated-cropped')



Naturally, under my story, the pitch accent on the auxiliary realizes the focus feature on the focus associate of *too*. In other words, the prosody of refutations and confirmations with *too* is not substantially different from regular utterances with *too*: both *too* and its focus associate carry a pitch accent. It's just that often refutations with *too* will also carry the contradiction contour, because they are, well, refutations.

6 Conclusion

In this paper, I have discussed novel data on confirmatory uses of additive particles, thus, complementing previous discussions of refutational uses of such particles. I have argued against the response particle analysis for either confirmatory or refutational uses of additive particles, proposing instead a semantics that is based on the same core semantics as “regular” uses of these particles. The key to capturing the confirmatory and refutational effects was then in identifying the correct focus alternatives: alternative projected commitments with respect to a polar issue *p*? in refutational uses vs. alternative performances of a speech act making the same projected commitment in confirmatory uses.

As I discussed throughout the paper, many open questions and directions for future research remain, including, but not limited to: a more comprehensive analysis of the syntax of confirmations and refutations with additive particles that matches the semantics proposed here; further exploration of the various idiosyncrasies of such uses; a story for what exactly the locus of variation is between the language varieties that do vs. don't have confirmatory vs. refutational uses of this or that additive particle; further cross-linguistic exploration of uses of additive particles in responses; a better understanding of the varieties of focus involved in confirmatory and refutational uses of additive particles.

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